MathCAS v2

Getting started with numeric work

Development build, November 2026

This tutorial is for people who want numbers out of MathCAS: evaluating formulas to any number of digits, finding roots and minima, writing fast numeric loops and running simulations with random numbers. It assumes no earlier knowledge of MathCAS. Work through it at the REPL; every example was run on the current build and its output is copied unchanged.

Contents

1 Setting up **1**

2 Three kinds of numbers **2**

3 Machine reals and their limits **3**

4 Arbitrary precision with balls **3**

5 Complex numbers **4**

6 Exact first, numbers last **4**

7 Iterations **5**

8 Finding roots **5**

9 Finding minima and maxima **6**

10 Fast numeric loops: the compiler **6**

11 Random numbers and simulation **7**

12 Failures, limits and interrupts **8**

13 Quick reference **8**

14 Coming next **9**

1 Setting up

The distribution folder (or the installed program) holds `mc-repl.exe`, the interactive REPL, which also runs scripts and notebooks; `mc-kernel.exe` and `mc-lsp.exe` for editors; `mc-bench.exe`, the benchmark harness; `examples\` and the VS Code extension. Start the REPL and type an expression; its value is printed below it.

```
mc> 1/3 + 1/6
1/2
mc> exp(1.5)
4.4816890703380645
```

Useful REPL commands while doing numerics:

`:time`	toggle timing: prints `time: ... ms` after each result
`:load file.mc`	read and run a script
`:history`, `:redo [k]`	show earlier inputs, run one again
Ctrl+C	stop a long computation and keep the session

Longer work goes into a script file `work.mc`, run with `mc-repl work.mc` (add `-i` to stay in the REPL afterwards). `say(a, b, ...)` prints its arguments from a script.

2 Three kinds of numbers

MathCAS keeps three kinds of numbers apart, and knowing which one you hold is the key to numeric work.

Kind	Written	Behaviour
exact	`3`, `2/7`, `sqrt(2)`, `pi`	integers and rationals of any size; constants and roots stay symbolic
machine real	`1.5`, `2.0e-8`, `n(x)`	IEEE double precision: fast, about 16 digits, no error tracking
ball	`1.25~30`, `n(x, 30)`	a value with a guaranteed error bound, at any precision

Exact arithmetic never rounds. `n` turns an exact quantity into a number: with one argument into a machine real, with a digit count into a ball.

```
mc> q = 1/3 + 2/7
mc> q
13/21
mc> n(q)
0.6190476190476191
mc> n(q, 40)
0.6190476190476190476
```

3 Machine reals and their limits

Machine reals are what most numeric software uses. They are fast, but they round every operation, silently:

```
mc> 0.1 + 0.2
0.30000000000000004
mc> 1.0e30 + 1 - 1.0e30
0.0
mc> 10^30 + 1 - 10^30
1
```

The second line lost the `1` entirely: next to 10^{30} it falls below the 16 digits a machine real carries. The exact computation on the third line has no such problem. This is the usual pattern in MathCAS: *compute exactly while you can, turn into numbers as late as possible.*

4 Arbitrary precision with balls

`n(x, d)` evaluates `x` with at least `d` correct digits. The result is a *ball*: a midpoint and a radius that is guaranteed to enclose the true value. MathCAS prints only the digits that the radius guarantees.

```
mc> n(pi, 50)
3.14159265358979323846264338327950288419716939937510 5821
mc> n(sqrt(2), 40)
1.4142135623730950488016887242096980785696719
mc> n(exp(1), 30)
2.718281828459045235360287471352 6625
mc> n(euler_gamma, 30)
0.577215664901532860606512090082 4024
```

You can also write a ball directly: `1.25~20` is 1.25 with 20 correct digits.

Balls track their own error. When digits are lost, the ball knows, and prints fewer:

```
mc> b = 1~20
mc> (b + 10^-15) - b
1.000e-15
mc> n(sqrt(2), 20)^2 - 2
ball(-2.0679515313825691872e-25, 4.08e-25)
```

Starting from 20 digits, the subtraction leaves only four. The second result is a number so close to zero that not a single digit is certain, so MathCAS shows the ball as it is: a midpoint and a radius. A ball whose interval contains zero is the honest answer to "is this zero?": as far as 20 digits can tell.

Tip. When a result has fewer digits than you asked for, the computation lost precision on the way (a cancellation like the one above). Ask for more digits at the start: `n(expr, 50)` instead of `n(expr, 20)`.

Functions of balls. Every elementary function (`exp`, `log`, `sin` … `tanh`, `sqrt`, powers) evaluates on balls to any precision. Large arguments are no problem, because the argument reduction is done with enough digits:

```
mc> n(sin(10^20), 20)
-0.64525128526578084420 5812
mc> n(exp(100), 20)
2.68811714181613544841263e43
```

Working with the digits. A few helpers for the boundary between numbers and exact values:

```
mc> rationalize(0.75)
3/4
mc> rationalize(n(pi), 1/1000)
201/64
mc> set_precision(0.1, 30)
0.100000000000000005551115123126
mc> chop(n(exp(pi*1im)))
-1.0
```

`set_precision` shows that the machine real `0.1` is not one tenth: it is the nearest binary fraction, and with 30 digits you see the difference.

5 Complex numbers

The imaginary unit is written `im`, as in `3 + 4im`. Machine complex numbers and complex balls print as `complex(re, im)`.

```
mc> abs(3 + 4im)
5
mc> n(exp(1 + 2im))
complex(-1.1312043837568135, 2.4717266720048188)
mc> n(exp(1 + 2im), 30)
complex(-1.131204383756813638431255255510794 7, 2.4717266720048189276169308935516 65)
mc> n(sqrt(-2))
complex(0.0, 1.4142135623730951)
```

`re`, `im_part`, `conjugate` and `arg` take complex numbers apart.

6 Exact first, numbers last

Many questions have an exact answer that MathCAS can find; you then evaluate it to as many digits as you need. Differentiation, integration and series are symbolic:

```
mc> d(sin(x)^2, x)
2*cos(x)*sin(x)
mc> integrate(1/(1 + x^2), [x, 0, 1])
(1/4)*pi
mc> n(integrate(1/(1 + x^2), [x, 0, 1]), 30)
0.785398163397448309615660845819875 7
mc> series(exp(x), x, 0, 5)
1 + x + x^2/2 + x^3/6 + x^4/24 + x^5/120 + O(x^6)
```

The same holds for sums: add exactly, then evaluate.

```
mc> n(sum(map(k => 1/k^2, range(1000))), 30)
1.643934566681559803139058023822215 6
```

Lists of numbers come from `range`, `table`, `map` and `nest_list`; `n` works on whole lists.

```
mc> n(range(0, 1, 1/4))
[0.0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0]
mc> table(n(k*pi/4), k, range(0, 4))
[0.0, 0.7853981633974483, 1.5707963267948966, 2.356194490192345, 3.141592653589793]
```

7 Iterations

`nest_list(f, x, k)` applies `f` to `x` `k` times and keeps every step: a fixed-point iteration in one line. Newton's method for $\sqrt{2}$, $x \mapsto (x + 2/x)/2$, doubles the number of correct digits each step:

```
mc> nest_list(x => (x + 2/x)/2, 1.0, 5)
[1.0, 1.5, 1.4166666666666665, 1.4142156862745097, 1.4142135623746899,
    1.414213562373095]
```

The same iteration on a 30-digit ball needs only one more step to reach 30 digits, and the result says how many it has:

```
mc> nest(x => (x + 2/x)/2, 1~30, 6)
1.41421356237309504880168872421
```

Symbolic and numeric work combine naturally: here is Newton's method for any function, with the derivative computed symbolically once.

```
fn newton(f, x0, steps) = {
  var x = x0
  let df = d(f(t), t)          # the derivative, exactly
  for i in range(steps) { x = x - f(x)/rewrite(df, [t -> x]) }
  x
}
```

```
mc> newton(t => t^2 - 2, 1.0, 6)
1.414213562373095
mc> newton(t => t^2 - 2, 1~50, 8)
1.41421356237309504880168872420969807856967187538
```

Of course you rarely need to write this yourself: that is what `find_root` is for.

8 Finding roots

`find_root(f, [x, x0])` finds a root of `f` (or a solution of `lhs == rhs`) near the starting value `x0`. It uses Newton's method with the exact derivative. The result is a list of rules, so you can substitute it into other expressions.

```
mc> find_root(cos(x) - x, [x, 1])
[x -> 0.7390851332151607]
mc> r = find_root(cos(x) - x, [x, 1])
mc> rewrite(x, r)
0.7390851332151607
```

The second argument chooses the method:

`[x, x0]`	Newton from `x0` (exact derivative; secant steps when there is none)
`[x, x0, x1]`	secant method from two starting values
`[x, x0, a, b]`	Brent's method inside the bracket $[a, b]$ (a sign change is required)
`[[x, x0], [y, y0]]`	a system of equations: Newton with the exact Jacobian, Broyden as a fallback

```
mc> find_root(x^3 - 2x - 5, [x, 2, 3])
[x -> 2.0945514815423265]
mc> find_root([x^2 + y^2 - 4, x - y], [[x, 1], [y, 1]])
[x -> 1.4142135623730951, y -> 1.4142135623730951]
mc> find_root(x^2 + 1, [x, 1 + 1im])
[x -> complex(0.0, 1.0)]
```

A complex starting value searches in the complex plane, as on the last line.

Many digits. The option `digits: d` refines the machine root with balls. For a simple root of a real function in one variable, the result is *verified*: the ball is proved to contain exactly one root.

```
mc> find_root(cos(x) == x, [x, 1], digits: 40)
[x -> 0.739085133215160641655312087673873404013]
mc> find_root(sin(x), [x, 3], digits: 60)
[x -> 3.141592653589793238462643383279502884197169399375105820974 9]
```

When it fails. A root finder that cannot converge does not stop your session. It returns a `failure` value with its best estimate and an error estimate:

```
mc> find_root(exp(x) + 1, [x, 0])
failure(not_converged, find_root, [x -> -8136.132507311752], 8125.743451212822)
```

($e^x + 1$ has no real root; Newton's method ran off to $-\infty$.) Failures are ordinary values: test them with `is_failure`, and choose a different starting value or a bracket.

9 Finding minima and maxima

`find_minimum(f, [x, x0])` returns the minimum value and where it is attained; `find_maximum` works the same way. Several variables use BFGS with the exact gradient.

```
mc> find_minimum(x^4 - 3x^2 + x, [x, 1])
[-1.0702301817761541, [x -> 1.1309011226299859]]
mc> find_maximum(sin(x)*exp(-x/5), [x, 1])
[0.7450600126415114, [x -> 1.373400766945016]]
mc> find_minimum((x - 1)^2 + 100(y - x^2)^2, [[x, -1], [y, 1]])
[0.0, [x -> 1.0, y -> 1.0]]
```

The last one is Rosenbrock's banana function, a classic hard case: a long curved valley with its minimum at $(1, 1)$.

A precision subtlety. Near a minimum a function is flat, so its value changes very little when the position does. A minimiser can therefore locate the *value* to full precision but the *position* only to about half the digits:

```
mc> f = x^3 - 6x^2 + 9x + 1
mc> find_minimum(f, [x, 2.5])
[0.9999999999999929, [x -> 3.0000000298023224]]
mc> find_root(d(f, x), [x, 2.5])
[x -> 3.0]
```

When you need the position accurately, solve $f'(x) = 0$ with `find_root`, as on the last line.

10 Fast numeric loops: the compiler

Loops written in MathCAS are interpreted, which costs about a microsecond per operation. For numeric loops MathCAS has a compiler that produces machine code. A function qualifies when its parameters are typed (`Int` or `Real`) and its body uses arithmetic, comparisons, `if`, `let`/`var`, `while`, `for` over ranges and the elementary functions. Put `@compiled` before `fn`, or call `compile(f)` later.

```
fn slow(n: Int) = { var s = 0.0; for k in range(n) { s = s + sin(1.0*k) }; s }
```

```
mc> :time
timing on
mc> slow(200000)
-0.03338662721108862
time: 1.143 s
mc> compile(slow)
slow
mc> slow(200000)
-0.03338662721108862
time: 1.136 ms
```

A thousand times faster, with the same result to the last bit. That is a guarantee, not luck: whenever compiled code meets something it cannot do natively (an integer overflow, the square root of a negative number, a function it does not know), the call falls back to the interpreter. Compiling never changes an answer.

Two more examples: the trapezoidal rule for $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,dx$, and the logistic map, a classic of chaos.

```
@compiled fn trap(m: Int) = {
  let h = 1.0/m
  var s = 0.5*(exp(0.0) + exp(-1.0))
  for k in range(m - 1) { s = s + exp(-(k*h)^2) }
  s*h
}
@compiled fn logistic(r: Real, n: Int) = {
  var x = 0.5
  for k in range(n) { x = r*x*(1.0 - x) }
  x
}
```

```
mc> trap(1000)
0.7468240714991843
mc> logistic(3.7, 1000)
0.8101078985832381
```

`compiled_info(f)` shows what the compiler made of a function: parameter and result types, code size, compile time, and how many calls ran compiled or fell back.

```
mc> compiled_info(trap)
[params -> [Int], result -> Real, hir_nodes -> 41, lir_instructions -> 73, code_bytes
    -> 856, back_end -> "cranelift", compile_microseconds -> 1591, inlined -> [], state
    -> "active", runs -> 1, declines -> 0]
```

Tip. Compile the inner loop, not the whole program. Exact arithmetic, symbolic work and balls stay in the interpreter, where they belong: at high precision the arithmetic itself, not the interpreter, takes the time.

11 Random numbers and simulation

The session has one random generator. `seed(n)` makes a run reproducible.

`random_real()`, `random_real([a, b], n)`	uniform reals in $[0, 1)$ or $[a, b)$; with `n`, a list
`random_integer([a, b], n)`	uniform integers from `a` to `b`
`random_normal(mu, sigma)`	normally distributed reals
`random_choice(xs)`, `random_sample(xs, n)`	elements of a list, with and without repetition

```
mc> seed(42)
mc> random_real()
0.3354948980859701
mc> random_real([0, 10], 3)
[1.5456113417635597, 9.64328247450341, 4.275784977896785]
mc> random_integer([1, 6], 5)
[3, 6, 5, 6, 3]
```

A Monte Carlo estimate of π: the fraction of random points in the unit square that fall inside the quarter circle is $\pi/4$.

```
mc> seed(7)
mc> 4.0*count_if(range(100000), k => random_real()^2 + random_real()^2 < 1)/100000
3.14604
```

The error of such an estimate shrinks like $1/\sqrt{N}$: a hundred times more points for one more digit. (Compiled code cannot draw random numbers yet, so simulations like this one run interpreted; this is being added.)

12 Failures, limits and interrupts

Numeric work fails in ordinary ways: an iteration does not converge, a value is not a number, a computation takes too long. MathCAS reports all of these as values instead of crashing or hanging:

- `failure(not_converged, f, estimate, error)`: a solver gave up; the estimate is often still useful.
- `failure(not_numeric, f, point)`: the function did not give a number at some point (a typo in a variable name is the usual cause).
- `failure(division_by_zero)`, `failure(argument, f, k)`: bad input.
- **Ctrl+C** interrupts any computation, compiled loops included, and keeps the session and its definitions.

`is_failure(v)` and `failure_tag(v)` let a script react to them.

13 Quick reference

Write	Meaning
`n(x)`, `n(x, d)`	machine real; ball with at least `d` correct digits
`1.25~30`	a ball literal with 30 digits
`precision(x)`, `accuracy(x)`	correct digits: relative, absolute
`set_precision(x, d)`, `rationalize(x, tol)`, `chop(x)`	change precision, back to exact, drop tiny parts
`pi`, `e`, `euler_gamma`, `catalan`, `im`	constants
`re`, `im_part`, `abs`, `arg`, `conjugate`	complex parts
`floor`, `ceiling`, `round`, `clip`, `rescale`, `sign`	rounding and ranges
`d(f, x)`, `integrate(f, x)`, `integrate(f, [x, a, b])`	exact derivative, antiderivative, definite integral
`series(f, x, x0, k)`	power series to order `k`
`find_root(f, [x, x0])` and variants	roots (Newton, secant, Brent, systems, complex)
`find_minimum`, `find_maximum`	local extrema (Brent, BFGS)
`nest(f, x, k)`, `nest_list(f, x, k)`	iterate a function
`range`, `table`, `map`, `sum`, `total`	build and reduce lists
`@compiled fn`, `compile(f)`, `compiled_info(f)`	compile to machine code, inspect
`seed`, `random_real`, `random_integer`, `random_normal`	random numbers
`option: value` after the arguments	options, e.g. `digits: 40`

14 Coming next

Numeric integration (`n_integrate`, for integrals with no closed form such as $\int_0^1 e^{-x^2}\,dx$, which `integrate` leaves unevaluated today), differential equations (`n_dsolve`), compiled random numbers and complex arithmetic, packed numeric arrays, and plots. Special functions (`gamma`, `zeta`, Bessel functions), linear algebra and equation solving follow after.